Saturday, November 14, 2026

St. John Henry Newman

Priest, Cardinal, Doctor of the Church · Feast, October 9



John Henry Newman, Sir John Everett Millais, 1881[1]

1. John Everett Millais, *John Henry Newman*, 1881; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** born in the City of London, the eldest of six children.[2]
- **Born:** February 21, 1801.[3]
- **Died:** at Edgbaston, Birmingham, on August 11, 1890.[4]
- **Feast:** October 9, an Optional Memorial in the General Roman Calendar.[5]
- **Titles:** Anglican priest and leader of the Oxford (Tractarian) Movement; received into the Catholic Church in 1845; Oratorian; Cardinal from 1879; canonized in 2019; declared a Doctor of the Church.[6][7][8][9][10]

✠ His Life in Brief

Newman went up to Trinity College, Oxford, in 1816 and was elected a fellow of Oriel in 1822.[11]

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2. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), birth.
3. Ibid.
4. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), death.
5. United States Conference of Catholic Bishops, "Saint John Henry Newman" (Washington, DC: USCCB, n.d.), on the Optional Memorial.
6. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), Tractarian Movement and Littlemore.
7. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), reception into the Church.
8. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), cardinalate.
9. Vatican News, report on the canonization Mass, October 13, 2019.
10. Vatican News, "St. John Henry Newman inscribed in General Roman Calendar" (February 3, 2026).
11. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), schooling and Oriel.

- He was ordained an Anglican priest on June 13, 1824.[12]
- He led the Oxford Movement, then stopped the Tracts, gave up St. Mary's and withdrew to Littlemore in lay communion.[13]
- On October 9, 1845, Father Dominic, a Passionist, received him into the Catholic Church.[14]
- He brought the Oratory of St. Philip Neri to England, and addressed Ireland in 1852 on the "Idea of a University."[15] [16]
- Leo XIII made him Cardinal-Deacon of St. George on May 12, 1879.[17]
- He died on August 11, 1890.[18] Pope Francis canonized him on October 13, 2019, and he was later declared a Doctor of the Church.[19] [20]

✠ Famous Excerpt: by Newman, and about him

> *"To be deep in history is to cease to be a Protestant."*[21]

Newman wrote this in the Introduction to his *Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*.[22] At his canonization, Pope Francis quoted him on the holiness of daily life: *"The Christian is*

12. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), ordination.
13. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Newman."
14. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Newman."
15. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), the Oratory.
16. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), *Idea of a University*.
17. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Newman."
18. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Newman."
19. Vatican News, canonization Mass.
20. Vatican News, "Newman inscribed."
21. John Henry Newman, *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*, 1878 ed., Introduction, sec. 5.
22. Ibid.

> *cheerful, easy, kind, gentle, courteous, candid, unassuming; has no pretence… with so little that is unusual or striking in his bearing, that he may easily be taken at first sight for an ordinary man."*[23]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: know who made you, and what you are for. In his *Meditations and Devotions* Newman teaches that God has created each person for a particular service.[24]

Exercise: read the meditation below slowly once, and write down one ordinary duty of today that is part of that service.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "The early Church is not the Church of today." Newman answered with history. His *Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine* held that the ancient Church cannot be fitted to Protestantism: "To be deep in history is to cease to be a Protestant."[25] The *Apologia* was a classic from the day it was completed, and is the chief authority for his early thoughts.[26]

✠ 3. Theology

- **Development of doctrine:** his *Essay on Development* was a major work, written as he came into the Church.[27]

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23. Pope Francis, homily at the canonization Mass, October 13, 2019, quoting Newman, *Parochial and Plain Sermons*, V, 5.
24. John Henry Newman, *Meditations and Devotions*, Part III, "Hope in God—Creator," March 7.
25. Newman, *Development*, Intro., sec. 5.
26. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), the *Apologia*.
27. Newman, *Development*, Intro., sec. 5.

- **Faith and assent:** in later life he began the *Grammar of Assent*, on how the mind comes to assent to faith.[28]
- **The soul's last journey:** *The Dream of Gerontius* (1865) set his beliefs about death in verse.[29]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Optional Memorial of St. John Henry Newman (Roman Missal, October 9):[30]
O God, who bestowed on the Priest Saint John Henry Newman the grace to follow your kindly light and find peace in your Church, graciously grant that, through his intercession and example, we may be led out of shadows and images into the fullness of your truth. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever.

"Lead, Kindly Light", written by Newman at sea in 1833, first stanza:[31] [32]
Lead, Kindly Light, amid the encircling gloom
Lead Thou me on!
The night is dark, and I am far from home—
Lead Thou me on!
Keep Thou my feet; I do not ask to see
The distant scene—one step enough for me.

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28. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), the *Grammar of Assent*.
29. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), *The Dream of Gerontius*.
30. *The Roman Missal*, Optional Memorial of St. John Henry Newman, Priest and Doctor of the Church (October 9), Collect, English text as confirmed August 4, 2026.
31. John Henry Newman, "The Pillar of the Cloud" ("Lead, Kindly Light"), June 16, 1833, in *Verses on Various Occasions*, no. 90.
32. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, s.v. "Newman, John Henry" (New York: Robert Appleton, 1911), *Lead, Kindly Light*.

From Newman's *Meditations and Devotions*:[33]

God has created me to do Him some definite service; He has committed some work to me which He has not committed to another. I have my mission—I never may know it in this life, but I shall be told it in the next.

Practice: Pray the Collect once today, and one stanza of "Lead, Kindly Light" in the evening.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Newman followed the kindly light of truth, one step at a time, from Oxford into the Church.[34] [35]

St. John Henry Newman, pray for us.

33. Newman, *Meditations*, March 7.
34. Newman, "Lead, Kindly Light."
35. *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Newman."